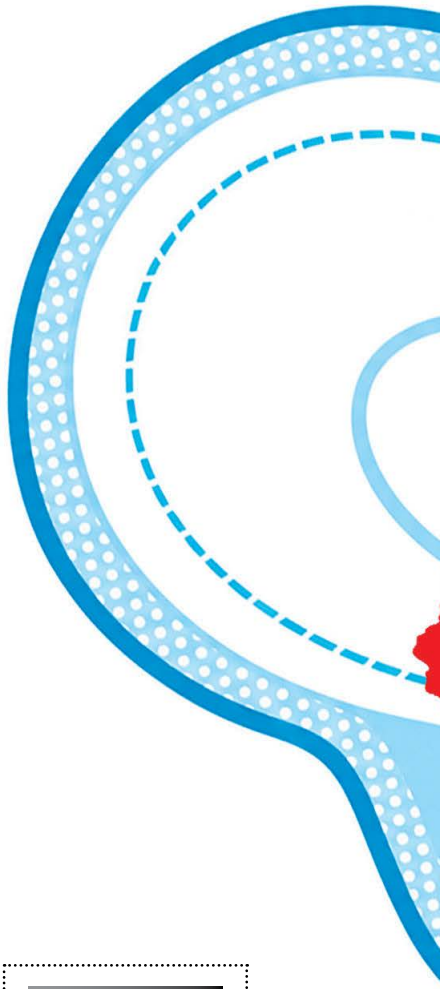
THE MENSTRUAL MAKEOVER

Menstrual hygiene in India has come a long way in recent years. Awareness campaigns and product innovations are breaking taboos and making it a smoother period for women in the country

By **SONALI ACHARJEE**
Illustration by **NILANJAN DAS**



WHEN 33-YEAR-OLD SONALI MUKHERJEE, A FREELANCE GRAPHIC DESIGNER, RETURNED to her hometown of Indore after five years studying and working in Canada, one of the unexpected changes she noticed was the periodcare aisle in department stores. "Before I left, pads would rub against the inner thighs and leave you feeling damp and uncomfortable. Now, they're so much softer and more breathable. You don't have that horrible sogginess or itchiness all the time," she says. "I didn't even know period panties were available here." Alongside, her younger cousins in the city seem more comfortable talking about menstruation than she does herself.

The change that Mukherjee sees is not limited to India's big cities, and is the result of a sustained and concerted effort. Numbers confirm how dramatically India's menstrual hygiene landscape has changed. Data from the sixth round of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6) show that the use of hygienic menstrual protection among women aged 15-24 has risen to 79.2 per cent, from 78 per cent in NFHS-5 and 57.6 per cent in NFHS-4. Government initiatives like Kerala's She Pad programme have helped hundreds of thousands of girls break down taboos around periods and learn proper menstrual hygiene—the state has distributed menstrual cups with training on safe use. Karnataka, too, has announced plans to distribute over one million menstrual cups to schoolgirls under its Shuchi scheme for 2025-26.

Companies have aided the effort and departed from earlier attempts to simply absorb the flow. Today, they are releasing products that prevent rashes, help with overnight use and postpartum recovery, and even provide sustainable options for the environmentally conscious. The market has ballooned, according to MarkNtel Advisors, a market research and consulting firm, which estimates India's menstrual care market to be around $940 million, or roughly Rs 8,000 crore, in 2025, growing to $1.07 billion, or close to Rs 9,000-9,500 crore, in 2026.

"Awareness about menstrual hygiene has improved significantly over the years," says Dr Lipi Sharma, consultant, Obstetrics and Gynaecology, ShardaCare-HealthC-



"The expansion of menstrual products recognises that women's needs are different. A schoolgoing teenager, an athlete, a working professional and a new mother may all need different solutions"

DR SHILPA GHOSH, *Senior Director & Unit Head, Obstetrics & Gynaecology, Max Super Speciality Hospital, Dwarka, Delhi*